

# Diatonic and chromatic harmony

Diatonic harmony is built from the pitches within a key signature, while chromatic harmony introduces dissonance that either diverges from the given key signature or has no key at all.

## Dissonance within a key

It is still possible to write dissonantly within diatonic music. Indeed, the creation and resolution of tension—on which many musical and harmonic narratives depend—demands a degree of dissonance.

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### ▽ Mozart's *Symphony No. 1*

The opening melody of Mozart's first symphony (which he composed at the age of eight) could hardly be simpler—an E♭ major arpeggio in three octaves. The highlighted notes in the treble clef show minor and major seconds that clash with the E♭ major harmony.

**Allegro molto**

The B in the bass clashes with the A♭ in the treble.

## Chromatic harmony

Since chromatic harmony departs from the home key signature, it pulls the music in another direction—toward a different key signature. The term “chromatic” derives from the Greek word for color. Notes outside a given key signature give the melody, or chord, a particular “color” to the ears.

The rests further disrupt continuity and make the phrase feel jagged.

### ◁ Mozart's *Symphony No. 40*

In the finale of his penultimate symphony, Mozart writes a unison melody in G minor, which goes through all the 12 half steps of the chromatic scale.